FIGHTERBASE

# Low-carb

## Diet guide

Fewer starchy carbs, more protein and veg.



Prepared 11 October 2026 for FighterBase members. Eating styles library, one of a set.

> DRAFT: not yet reviewed by a registered dietitian. General information only, not medical advice. Check with your doctor or a registered dietitian before changing how you eat, especially if you have a medical condition, are pregnant, or are under 18.

USING FIGHTERBASE

# How to use this diet guide

This diet guide is part of your eating styles library in the FighterBase app. The pages that follow are built to be skimmed. You do not need to read it all at once.

1. **Open Nutrition**
   In the app, open the **Nutrition** tab and tap **Eating styles**.

2. **Tap Low-carb**
   Read the short summary, what to eat, what to go easy on, and what to watch.

3. **Follow it**
   Tap **Follow this style**. Recipes and the Foods list then filter to match, so you only see what fits. You can follow more than one style.

4. **Download the PDFs**
   Use **Full food list** and **Diet guide** to save these to your phone. Handy for the shop or a restaurant.

5. **Log it and train**
   Meals you log count towards your day. Spend your energy on training, not on reading labels.

> Looking for the full list of foods? Download the **Full food list** PDF from the same screen. It names every allowed and avoided food.

THE BASICS

# What is Low-carb?

Cuts back on bread, pasta, rice and sugar, without going as far as keto. Meals lean on protein, veg and healthy fats.

## Where it comes from

Cutting carbohydrate to manage weight has been written about since the 1860s (William Banting's 'Letter on Corpulence'). Modern low-carb eating grew through the 1970s to 2000s, and today covers anything from moderate (about 100 to 150 g carbs a day) to very low (under 50 g).

## The main ideas

1. Build meals around protein, non-starchy vegetables and healthy fats.
2. Cut back the big carb sources: bread, pasta, rice, potatoes, sugar, sweet drinks and most cereals.
3. Keep some carbs from vegetables, berries and legumes, depending on how low you go.
4. There is no single carb number. Pick a level you can keep up.
5. Fibre still matters: lots of vegetables, some seeds and nuts.

## Who it suits

- People who feel better with fewer starchy carbs
- People who want to lose body fat in a steady way outside a fight camp
- People who snack heavily on sugar and want a reset

**Talk to your doctor or a registered dietitian first if:**

- You take medication for diabetes or blood pressure (doses can need changing)
- You have kidney, liver or gall bladder problems
- You are pregnant, breastfeeding or under 18
- You have ever had an eating disorder

TRAINING

# Fuel for training

- Hard, fast sessions (sparring, intervals, wrestling rounds) burn carbohydrate. Many fighters on low-carb add some carbs back around those sessions.
- A simple approach: keep carbs low on rest days and lighter sessions, and eat fruit, oats or rice around your toughest training.
- Expect a few weeks of feeling flat when you start. Drink plenty of water and do not skimp on salt.
- Eat enough overall. Low-carb plus under-eating is the usual cause of poor sparring and bad sleep.

> Many people keep a portion of carbs before or after hard sessions and go lower on rest days.

## Nutrients to keep an eye on

**Fibre**
gut health and fullness
Where: vegetables, chia and flax seeds, berries, nuts

**Magnesium**
muscle and sleep
Where: leafy greens, nuts, seeds, dark chocolate

**Sodium and potassium**
water balance, cramps
Where: salt, broth, avocado, leafy greens

**Vitamin C**
recovery and connective tissue
Where: peppers, berries, citrus, broccoli

## Common mistakes

- Cutting carbs and calories at the same time, then training hard
- Not drinking or salting enough, causing headaches and cramps early on
- Eating lots of processed 'low-carb' products
- Skipping vegetables and getting constipated

EVERYDAY LIFE

# Labels, eating out and swaps

## Reading labels

- Sugar can hide as: dextrose, maltodextrin, glucose syrup, honey, agave, fruit juice concentrate
- 'Sugar-free' foods can still carry starch or sugar alcohols (maltitol, sorbitol)
- Look at total carbohydrate per portion, not just 'of which sugars'

## Eating out

- Order a burger or steak without the bun and swap chips for salad or vegetables.
- Ask for dressings and sauces on the side.
- Grilled meat or fish plus vegetables is nearly always available.
- Skip bread baskets and sweet drinks.

## Easy swaps

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Pasta | → | Courgetti, shirataki noodles or extra vegetables |
| Rice | → | Cauliflower rice |
| Bread | → | Lettuce wraps or a low-carb wrap |
| Sugar in tea | → | A sweetener or none |
| Crisps | → | Nuts, olives, pork scratchings or cheese |

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

# A sample week

One way a week could look. Portions and total food depend on you and your training.

| | Breakfast | Lunch | Dinner |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Mon** | Eggs, bacon, tomatoes | Chicken Caesar salad (no croutons) | Steak, green beans, mushrooms |
| **Tue** | Greek yoghurt, berries, nuts | Tuna salad with avocado | Salmon, broccoli, butter |
| **Wed** | Omelette with spinach and cheese | Leftover salmon salad | Chicken thighs, roasted vegetables |
| **Thu** | Sausages and eggs | Soup (no potato) with cheese | Beef mince, cauliflower rice, peppers |
| **Fri** | Chia pudding with berries | Egg and bacon salad | Pork chops, cabbage, apple sauce (small) |
| **Sat** | Smoked salmon and scrambled eggs | Prawn and avocado salad | Chicken curry (no rice), greens |
| **Sun** | Full breakfast, no toast | Roast leftovers and salad | Roast meat, vegetables, a few roast potatoes if your plan allows |

## Snacks

Nuts · Cheese · Boiled eggs · Olives · Celery with nut butter · Greek yoghurt · Jerky (check sugar) · Dark chocolate (85% or higher)

## Shopping list

Meat, fish, eggs · Cheese, butter, cream, Greek yoghurt · Leafy and non-starchy vegetables · Berries · Nuts and seeds · Olive oil, avocado · Salt and herbs · Broth or stock cubes

GOOD TO KNOW

# Questions people ask

**How low is low?**

Anything from about 20 g to 130 g carbs a day. Under 50 g is usually called very low-carb or keto.

**Will I lose weight?**

Often at first, partly water. Over months it works like any plan: only if it helps you eat less overall.

**Can I still compete?**

Many do. Check how you perform in sparring on your plan well before a fight, not the week of it.

## Further reading

British Dietetic Association; Diabetes UK; NICE.



### For fighters and combat athletes

- **No eating style makes a rapid weight cut safe.** Sweating, fluid restriction and crash diets hurt performance and can be dangerous. Plan any weight cut with a registered sports dietitian and your coach, well before the weigh-in.
- **Fuel the training first.** Hard sparring and conditioning need carbohydrate and enough total food. If a style cuts a food group, have a plan to replace what is lost.
- **Protein across the day.** A common general range for people training hard is about 1.4 to 2.0 g per kg of body weight a day (draft range, to be confirmed by a dietitian).
- **Try changes in training, never in fight week.** Test new foods, supplements and timing well before competition.
- **Under 18, pregnant, or with a medical condition:** get advice from a doctor or dietitian before changing your diet.

FIGHTERBASE

# Train. Eat. Recover. Repeat.

Your eating styles library lives in the Nutrition tab. Pick a style, follow it, and get back to training.

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